



“For some years I have been afflicted with the belief that flight is possible to man. My disease has increased in severity and I feel that it will cost me an increased amount of money if not my life.”

WILBUR WRIGHT, 1900

FIGHT TO BE FIRST

BY 1900, THE DREAM OF ACHIEVING POWERED FLIGHT WAS CLOSE TO BECOMING REALITY. THE QUESTION BEING ASKED WAS – WHO WOULD GET THERE FIRST?

LATE IN THE AFTERNOON of Saturday, August 8, 1908, on a racetrack at Hunaudières outside Le Mans in western France, Wilbur Wright unhurriedly settled himself at the controls of a flying machine. Dressed in a gray business suit, a high starched collar, and a golf cap, this phlegmatic man was preparing for his first flight in Europe. He hoped to establish in the eyes of the world that he and his brother Orville had been the first to achieve heavier-than-air powered flight.

Watching from the stands was a handful of flight enthusiasts, most of whom had come in the hope and expectation that the American would fail. They all knew that the Wrights claimed to have flown as long ago as 1903, but there was widespread skepticism about this alleged conquest of the air. France had its own claimants to the title of “first to fly” – including Alberto Santos-Dumont, who had briefly lifted off the ground in a heavier-than-air machine in 1906, and Henri Farman, who had flown a full kilometer (3/5-mile) circuit earlier in



A RESERVED MAN

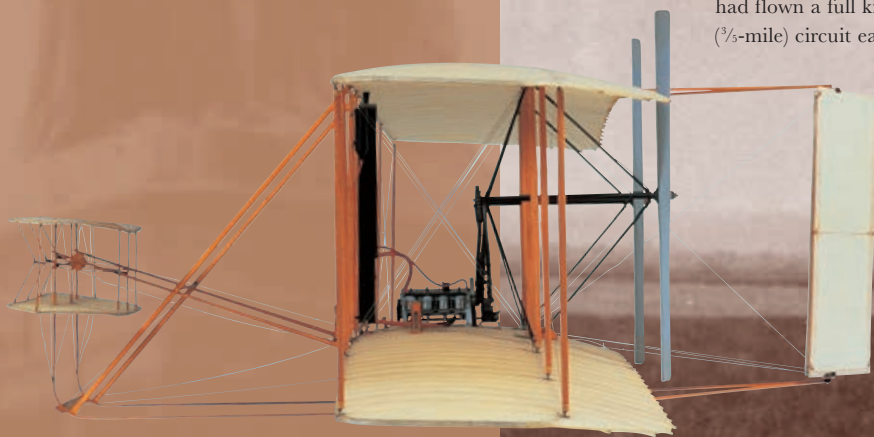
Although Wilbur Wright was a man of austere and reserved temperament, his private letters reveal a caustic sense of humor, as well as piercing intelligence.

1908. Since Wilbur Wright’s arrival in France, the press had been running articles deriding his claims to primacy; he was, they said, “not a flier, but a liar.”

Wilbur Wright cannot have been certain that he was about to prove the sceptics wrong. He had never operated this particular machine, the Type A. He seemed to take forever over his preparations, ignoring the crowd’s mounting impatience, until he finally announced: “Gentlemen, now I’m going to fly.” Wright’s assistants set the two propellers whirling, weights dropped from the catapult derrick,

and the flying machine sped along its launch rail and lifted into the air. Traveling at a height of about 30ft (10m), Wright approached the end of the racetrack and put his machine into a graceful banked turn to come back over the heads of the spectators. After completing one more circuit of the track, he brought the machine gently down on its skids. There was an uproar. Clapping and cheering, the spectators ran forward to mob the pilot. Lasting just 1 minute 45 seconds, the flight had exceeded any display of flying the French had ever seen.

Since that day at Le Mans, it has been generally – though not always universally – accepted that the Wright brothers were indeed the inventors of the first heavier-than-air machine capable of sustained, controlled, powered flight.



THE WRIGHT BROTHERS' 1903 FLYER

On December 17, 1903, Orville Wright made the world’s first powered heavier-than-air flight at Kill Devil Hills, Kitty Hawk, North Carolina. The Flyer flew for 12 seconds over a distance of 120ft (37m). On the fourth and final flight, with Wilbur at the controls, it flew for 59 seconds over a distance of 852ft (260m).